

DINNER WITH STRAHD

Medium Introduction (Neutral)

Goal Information
Base DC 18

Background

Strahd's Goals. Through this dinner, Strahd aims to gain a sense of the PCs' strengths and weaknesses, investigate their relationships to one another, and explore whether any PC might make a suitable successor or consort.

The Waitstaff. The dinner is staffed by Escher, a flamboyant male **vampire spawn**, and Sasha Ivlskova, a reserved female **vampire spawn**. Escher fears losing Strahd's interest, and Sasha is desperate to win back Strahd's favor and escape the prison of her crypt.

Sasha's Scheme. Sasha aims to present herself as a genuine accomplice to the PCs' schemes. However, her efforts are a facade, carried out in exchange for Strahd's promise to eventually free her from her crypt.

Master Manipulator. Strahd prefers listening to speaking and will always turn a personal anecdote into a question for a PC. He shows genuine interest at all times, and will even risk vulnerability by discussing the nature of vampirism.

Off-Limits. Strahd will never discuss the following topics: Sergei or the nature of his death; Tatyana's death or the events of her wedding day; or the source of Strahd's vampirism or reasons for obtaining it.

Maneuvers

Strahd's Welcome. When the PCs arrive, Strahd is playing a mournful melody on the pipe organ. When the song concludes, he turns and greets them by name, welcoming them to Ravenloft. As Escher and Sasha, assisted by two **unseen servants**, serve glasses of Red Dragon Crush, Strahd inquires after the PCs' health, their journey to the castle, and their time in Barovia.

The Dinner. When introductions have concluded, Strahd invites the PCs to be seated. Escher and Sasha, accompanied by the unseen servants, serve a feast of delicious food and drinks. Strahd takes a glass of wine and a serving of roast goat, but characters with passive Perception of 15 or more notice that Strahd never touches his food and his wine is a deeper, fuller red. As they eat, Strahd asks the PCs about their histories, interests, goals, and experiences while sharing sanitized details from his own past (see *Disclosures*).

Escher's Errand. Partway through dinner, Escher asks a PC for assistance in bringing up a fresh barrel of wine. If accompanied, he descends to the Wine Cellar (K63). Within the kitchen, the PC can see a dead Barovian strung up from the ceiling, blood slowly draining into a basin below. Escher responds: "You didn't forget that you were having dinner with monsters, did you?" before retrieving a barrel of Red Dragon Crush. (During this encounter, Sasha surreptitiously leaves a note in another PC's lap upstairs while refilling their glass; the note, if unfurled, reads: "Not everyone here is an enemy.")

Disclosures

Guests of the Castle (Neutral). Castle Ravenloft has seen many guests in its time, from the fool Pidwick to the saintly Tasha Petrovna and the archmage Khazan.

Origins of Barovia (Neutral). Strahd first came to Barovia hundreds of years ago in pursuit of a traitorous force that had slain his father (This is a lie). Struck by its beauty, he decided to make it the seat of his power, naming it "Barovia" for his father, King Barov.

Castle Ravenloft (Neutral). Castle Ravenloft was built on the ruins of an older fortress built by King Dostron the Hellborn. A small army of mages forged it from the rock of the Pillarstone of Ravenloft itself. The castle was named for Strahd's mother, Ravenovia.

Reactions

Studies of Magic. If one of the PCs mentions an interest in magic or dealings with dark powers, Strahd asks where they studied, how they gained their experience, or what drew them to their field of interest.

Theological Delves. If one of the PCs mentions their worship of a deity, their philosophy of morality, or their views on the natural order, Strahd engages them in a lively discussion on theology, philosophy, and/or ethics, happily playing the devil's advocate.

Why Ireena? If asked about Ireena, Strahd states that she bears the soul of the woman he once loved, confessing that—after centuries of mourning—he was overcome by emotion at the sight of her resemblance. (A DC 18 Insight check reveals that Strahd feels far less sentiment than his words might indicate.)

The Brides. If asked about his vampiric consorts, Strahd speaks highly of Ludmilla's intellect, Anastrasya's cunning, and Volenta's creativity. He insists that he despises waste, and believes that the immortality of vampirism is best shared with the talented.

Developments

After Dinner. When dinner comes to a close, Strahd offers the PCs a tour of Castle Ravenloft. See *Tour of the Castle*. If the PCs decline, Strahd invites them to dance with his consorts in the Audience Hall (K25). See *Dancing With the Brides*.

End of the Night. When the night's events conclude, Strahd escorts the PCs to the Great Entry, where Rahadin awaits. If the PCs have impressed Strahd, Rahadin is accompanied by three **unseen servants** bearing wrapped parcels on silver trays: small, personalized gifts for any PCs who impressed Strahd during their visit. Before the PCs depart, Strahd asks them to investigate and apprehend Rudolph van Richten—an "assassin" with a hatred of Vistani who "seeks to slay Strahd as the Vistani's protector"—promising each PC a treasure from his vault if they succeed. Regardless of their response, Strahd provides safe passage home via his black carriage.